

CREDIT CARDS WITH ZERO FOREX MARK-UP

cy conversion fees, and another 2–3% as exchange rate markup. That's up to ₹10,000 extra," says Motwani.

In dynamic currency conversion, you're offered the option to pay in INR instead of the local currency. It may seem convenient, but the merchant or acquiring bank sets the exchange rate, often with a markup.

However, some premium or travel-focused credit cards offer low or zero forex markup. But how beneficial are they? "Travellers should note that even with a reduced markup fee, the total forex markup cost could be significant, especially in case of high-value transactions. Moreover, some foreign merchants may also allow you to pay in INR, but this also entails dynamic conversion charges," says Rohit Chhibbar, Chief Business Officer, Credit Cards, Paisabazaar, a lending aggregator.

Always pay in the local currency of the visiting country to avoid dynamic conversion charges.

Another point to remember is that zero-forex markup cards may still use static network rates set by card providers like Visa or Mastercard. These are typically updated once or twice a day and can be up to 1% higher than the real-time interbank rate.

CASH/ATM WITHDRAWAL

Carrying some cash is necessary, depending on your destination. In countries like the US, cards are widely accepted. But in countries like Japan and Vietnam, you'll need physical currency, especially at local shops or markets.

Avoid buying currency at airports due to high markups. Banks may also charge substan-

 Credit Card	Annual Fee	Key Investors
 Federal Bank Scapia Credit Card	Nil	● 20% Scapia Coins on travel bookings made using the Scapia app ● 0% Scapia Coins on all domestic spends ● Unlimited access to domestic airport lounges on reaching ₹10,000 monthly spend
 ixigo AU Credit Card	Nil	● Up to 10 reward points on every ₹200 spent ● One complimentary international airport lounge visit with up to eight visits each to domestic airport and railway lounges per year
 IDFC FIRST WOW Credit Card	Nil	● Up to 4X reward points on every ₹150 spent ● 100% of the FD amount offered as credit limit ● No interest charges on ATM cash withdrawals worldwide for up to 45 days
 Niyo Global SBM Bank Secured Credit Card	Nil	● Complimentary international airport lounge access on meeting the spend-based condition ● No TCS on international spends ● Card accepted across 180+ countries for 130+ currency spends
 RBL World Safari Credit Card	₹3,000	● Up to five reward points on every ₹100 spent ● Two complimentary domestic airport lounge visits per quarter ● Complimentary Priority Pass membership with up to six international lounge visits per year
 IDFC FIRST Mayura Credit Card	₹5,999	● Up to 10X reward points on every ₹150 spent ● Up to 16 complimentary domestic airport lounge and spa and 16 international lounge visits in a year ● Up to 16 complimentary railway lounge visits at select Indian Railway terminals
 IndusInd Bank Pioneer Private Credit Card	₹25,000	● Up to three reward points on every ₹100 spent ● Unlimited access to domestic and international Priority Pass airport lounges per year with 12 guest visits to international lounges ● Unlimited domestic golf lessons/games and 4 international games per year
 Axis Bank Burgundy Private Credit Card	₹50,000 (Nil for Burgundy Private account holders)	● 15 EDGE reward points on every ₹200 spent ● Unlimited domestic and international airport lounge access with 12 guest visits each per year ● 50 complimentary golf rounds per year

NOTE ALL CARD INFORMATION IS SOURCED FROM THE CARD PROVIDER WEBSITES AS OF MAY 6, 2025 **SOURCE** PAISABAZAAR

tial premiums over IBR, therefore banks or online forex platforms offering real-time rates with low margins are better options.

ATM withdrawals abroad are convenient but expensive. Shetty argues that ATM transactions, es-

pecially withdrawals, attract steep charges. "For instance, Kotak Mahindra Bank charges \$2 for cash withdrawals and \$0.50 for balance enquiry transactions. IDFC First Bank charges \$1.5 and \$0.25 for ATM withdrawals and balance en-